

**Observation of Information Behavior and Public Space Design: CALS Main Library and
Barnes & Noble**

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Introduction

Public libraries and bookstores both serve as important spaces for information access, learning, and community engagement; however, they differ significantly in purpose, design, and user interaction. Public libraries are mission-driven institutions that prioritize equitable access to information and community support, while bookstores operate within a retail framework that emphasizes sales and consumer experience. Observing these two environments provides valuable insight into how physical space, services, and staff interactions shape user behavior.

This paper presents an observational analysis of two information environments: the Central Arkansas Library System (CALS) Main Library in North Little Rock, Arkansas, and a Barnes & Noble bookstore. Drawing from direct observation and professional experience, this study examines physical design, patron behavior, and staff interactions in both spaces. The goal is to better understand how each environment supports user needs and to evaluate their effectiveness as information and community spaces.

CALS Main Library

Community Profile

The CALS Main Library serves a diverse population within North Little Rock and the broader Pulaski County area. According to U.S. Census data, the community includes a wide range of age groups, income levels, and educational backgrounds. The area reflects both working-class and underserved populations, with many individuals relying on public services for access to technology, job resources, and educational support.

In addition to these demographic factors, access to library services is shaped by the number of libraries available to serve the population. Nationally, there are about five public libraries for every 100,000 people. However, in Arkansas, there are only about two public library systems per 100,000 people. This lower concentration means that each library serves a larger portion of the population, which can impact both access and visibility. As a result, libraries in Arkansas can sometimes feel hidden within the community—not intentionally, but because there are fewer locations serving more people. Increased visibility and promotion could potentially draw in more users than current resources can support, so libraries must balance outreach with their capacity to serve.

Compared to the broader U.S. population, the community served by CALS demonstrates a higher need for public access services, particularly in areas such as internet connectivity, workforce development, and literacy support. This demographic reality shapes the mission and service priorities of the library, reinforcing its role as a community-centered institution.

Observations: Physical Design

The CALS Main Library is a modern, multi-floor facility designed to accommodate a wide variety of user needs. The space includes clearly defined service areas such as a circulation desk, hold shelves, public computer stations, and reading/study spaces. Additional features such as makerspaces, meeting rooms, and collaborative areas reflect the evolving role of libraries as multifunctional community hubs.

One of the most notable aspects of the library's design is its openness and accessibility. The layout encourages movement throughout the building, while the availability of both quiet and

active spaces allows patrons to choose environments that best suit their needs. The presence of natural lighting and updated furnishings contributes to a welcoming atmosphere.

However, despite these strengths, navigation within the library can present challenges. Signage is present but not always intuitive, leading many patrons to rely on staff for direction. This suggests that while the space is visually appealing, there is room for improvement in wayfinding and spatial organization.

Importantly, the cleanliness and overall maintenance of the library play a critical role in shaping user experience. A well-maintained environment communicates professionalism, care, and respect for patrons, encouraging longer visits and more meaningful engagement with resources.

Observations: Staff and Patron Activities

Patron behavior within the CALS Main Library is largely goal-oriented. Many patrons enter the space with a specific purpose, such as retrieving holds, using computers, or accessing particular materials. The hold shelf is a high-traffic area, reflecting increased use of digital catalogs that allow patrons to reserve materials in advance.

In addition to general patron use, the library space is also shared by individuals experiencing homelessness, which reflects the inclusive nature of public libraries. These patrons often use the library as a safe, climate-controlled environment where they can rest, access computers, charge devices, and seek information about services. Their presence highlights the library's role as more than an information center—it functions as a critical public space that meets basic human needs. While most interactions involving these patrons were quiet and non-disruptive, their use of the space underscores the importance of maintaining a clean, organized, and welcoming

environment for all users. Libraries must balance openness with structure, ensuring that all patrons feel safe and respected while still preserving access for vulnerable populations. This aligns with research that positions libraries as community support systems and “second responders,” providing stability and resources to individuals in times of need (Fallows, 2019). Additionally, creating inclusive environments that serve diverse populations supports broader goals of equity and social justice within library services (Cooke & Sweeney, 2019; Gustina & Guinnee, 2017).

Public computer usage is consistently high, with patrons engaging in activities such as job searching, email communication, research, and document printing. A significant number of users require assistance with basic computer functions, highlighting the library’s critical role in supporting digital literacy.

Navigation is another key area where patron behavior reveals underlying challenges. Despite available signage, patrons frequently seek assistance from staff to locate materials or facilities. This indicates that the physical layout, while functional, may not fully support independent navigation for all users.

Staff interactions are frequent and essential. Library staff provide assistance with technology, locate materials, answer questions, and facilitate access to services. These interactions are typically brief but highly impactful, contributing to a positive user experience and reinforcing the library’s role as a supportive environment.

Barnes & Noble

Community Profile

Barnes & Noble serves a somewhat different demographic compared to the public library. While it is open to the general public, its primary audience consists of consumers with disposable income who are interested in purchasing books, gifts, and other retail items. The customer base often includes students, families, and casual readers, as well as individuals seeking a comfortable environment for leisure and browsing.

Compared to the CALS service population, Barnes & Noble's user base tends to reflect a more consumer-oriented demographic. Access to materials is dependent on purchasing power rather than public service provision, which fundamentally shapes how the space is used and experienced.

These differences become more apparent when observing how individuals interact with the space. By examining the layout, atmosphere, and user behavior within Barnes & Noble, it is possible to better understand how a consumer-focused environment influences the way people engage with books, information, and the overall experience of the space.

Observations: Physical Design

Barnes & Noble is designed to maximize comfort, browsing, and sales. The store features wide aisles, clearly labeled sections, and visually appealing displays that highlight new releases and popular titles. The inclusion of a café, seating areas, and designated sections such as children's books and magazines creates a relaxed and inviting environment.

The physical space is intentionally designed to encourage exploration. Unlike the library, where many visits are goal-oriented, Barnes & Noble promotes browsing behavior through its layout

and merchandising strategies. Displays are strategically placed to draw attention and influence purchasing decisions.

However, one notable challenge within the bookstore is organization. While sections are labeled, locating specific titles without staff assistance can be difficult. This reflects a design that prioritizes discovery over precision.

The cleanliness and aesthetic appeal of the space contribute significantly to its effectiveness. The store maintains a polished and comfortable environment, reinforcing its identity as a welcoming retail space where customers can spend extended periods of time.

Observations: Staff and Patron Activities

Patron behavior in Barnes & Noble differs from that observed in the library. Many customers engage in browsing, exploring different sections, and spending time reading or relaxing. The presence of the café encourages longer visits and creates a social atmosphere.

Staff interactions are less frequent and more transactional compared to the library. Employees primarily assist with locating items, processing purchases, and maintaining the store. While staff are available to help, customers are generally expected to navigate the space independently.

Unlike the library, where patrons often require assistance with technology or information access, interactions in the bookstore are typically brief and focused on retail needs. This reflects the fundamental difference in mission between the two environments.

Recommendations

Based on these observations, several recommendations can be made to improve user experience and service delivery, particularly within the public library environment.

First, enhancing wayfinding within the library should be a priority. Improved signage, clearer labeling, and more intuitive layout design could reduce confusion and allow patrons to navigate the space more independently. Incorporating visual cues or digital directories may further improve accessibility.

Second, maintaining clean and organized spaces should remain a central focus. As observed, the physical condition of the environment significantly influences how patrons interact with services. A well-maintained space encourages comfort, engagement, and repeated use.

Third, libraries can draw inspiration from bookstores in creating inviting and engaging environments. Elements such as comfortable seating, curated displays, and flexible spaces can enhance the user experience without compromising the library's mission.

Finally, continued investment in staff training and support is essential. Staff interactions are a defining feature of the library experience, and ensuring that employees are equipped to assist patrons effectively will strengthen service quality.

Lessons Learned and Conclusions

This observation highlights the critical role that physical space, service design, and institutional mission play in shaping user behavior. While both the CALS Main Library and Barnes & Noble provide access to information, they do so in fundamentally different ways.

The public library emerges as a vital community resource that prioritizes access, support, and inclusivity. It serves as a space where individuals can access technology, seek assistance, and engage with information regardless of financial means. In contrast, Barnes & Noble offers a comfortable and engaging retail experience that encourages browsing and leisure but is ultimately limited by its commercial nature.

One of the most significant takeaways from this study is the importance of clean, well-designed spaces. Physical environment is not merely aesthetic; it directly impacts usability, accessibility, and overall satisfaction. Additionally, the role of staff in facilitating access and supporting patrons is essential to the success of public library services.

As a library professional, these observations reinforce the importance of user-centered design, adaptability, and continuous improvement. By understanding how patrons interact with both physical and digital environments, libraries can better meet the evolving needs of their communities and remain relevant in an increasingly digital world.

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